

When I was a child, my father gave me a book about Python. Back then it was just another book, but as I read through it, experimenting with code, it became the start of my journey into the world of computer tech. What began as a hobby evolved into a strong force behind my academic growth. Over the past nine years, this passion for programming and technology has led me to explore different areas of computer science, from hackathons and ethical hacking to artificial intelligence and computer vision and I'm not planning to stop on that

Hackathons were my first step into practical programming. I participated in seven major events, winning five. Some hackathons' main prize was a summer internship in an IT company, and it was a chance for me to get invaluable experience in commercial development and have a look into developers' everyday working process. However, it wasn't just about winning; I love the satisfaction of teamwork, and the sense of accomplishment when everything came together. Hackathons taught me how to think critically under pressure and work in a team. These are skills I've applied in every subsequent project.

At the age of 13, I discovered information security, inspired by white-hat hackers like Kevin Mitnick and Jeff Moss. I was and I'm still amazed by their ability to think outside the box, finding unexpected ways to solve problems. This fascination led me to ethical hacking and CTF (Capture the Flag) competitions. In 2020, I formed a team and entered our first CTF. Despite the fact that we lost hard, I was motivated, because this was a new type of challenge for me, and I wanted to understand how to solve it. Over the next six months, we competed in 13 more events, consistently improving our rankings. By 2021, we reached the finals of the National Technical Olympiad (NTO), though our lack of experience with Windows systems and Active Directory kept us from the top spot.

After that, I decided to take a break from cybersecurity and turned my attention to AI. My friend invited me to listen to a lecture about AI. Although I didn't understand much, it was interesting and I decided to give it a shot. By spring of 2022, I competed in the regional WorldSkills AI track, earning second place. Unfortunately, in 2023, my family moved to the UK, and I was unable to participate on the national stage. I think it could be interesting. Nevertheless, I am confident that I will have another chance to gain such experience in the future.

In autumn of 2022, my team and I returned to CTF with renewed determination, and it became a triumphant year for us. We ranked among the top 50 teams in Russia, became winners at the NTO, and won in several local competitions. I also participated individually in the All-Russian School Olympiad in Information Security, achieving second place. Participating in competitions across Russia required frequent travel, and it gave me a chance to learn to adapt to unfamiliar environments and manage my time. Long train journeys gave me time to improve my communication skills, as I almost always had teammates by me.

In the summer of 2023, my family moved to the UK. Until November, I focused on adapting to a new academic rhythm, language, and culture. I missed the competitive atmosphere of CTFs and other tournaments so much. Back in Russia, when I wasn't participating in CTFs, I was solving maths Olympiads or playing for school in the volleyball team. To fill this gap, I decided to found my own club at college, focused on developing cybersecurity skills. I created a website with learning resources and held regular sessions for classmates,

explaining fundamental concepts. This experience was both enjoyable and helpful for improving my English conversational skills. In April 2024, I secured an internship with the UK-based startup Yal Digital, and this June we participated with development team in Microsoft GenAI Hackathon.